explaining that “influenced by positivistic and instrumentalist philosophies, many came to hold not only that it is difficult to find a coherent picture [of the quantum world] but that it is wrong to look for one—if not actually immoral then certainly unprofessional. Going further still, some asserted that atomic and subatomic particles do not *have* any definite properties in advance of observation.” Then Bell brought it back to Bertlmann’s socks:

> It is in the context of ideas like these that one must envisage the discussion of the Einstein-Podolsky-Rosen correlations. Then it is a little less unintelligible that the EPR paper caused such a fuss, and that the dust has not settled even now. It is as if we had come to deny the reality of Bertlmann’s socks, or at least of their colors, when not looked at. And as if a child has asked: How come they always choose different colors when they *are* looked at?How does the second sock know what the first has done?

Bell himself had answered the question of why entangled particles can’t be like Bertlmann’s socks—his theorem, and the experiments of Clauser and Aspect, showed that something much stranger must be going on. “Certain particular correlations, realizable according to quantum mechanics, are *locally inexplicable.* They cannot be explained, that is to say, without action at a distance,” Bell wrote. “You might shrug your shoulders and say ‘coincidences happen all the time’ or ‘that’s life.’ Such an attitude is indeed sometimes advocated by otherwise serious people in the context of quantum philosophy. But outside that peculiar context, such an attitude would be dismissed as unscientific. The scientific attitude is that correlations cry out for explanation.”

Aspect’s charm offensive had done wonders for quantum foundations, but indifference to the subject was still widespread among physicists. And, as Clauser knew well, there was little hope of finding a full-time job doing work on quantum foundations. Bell himself spent nearly all of his time at work doing particle physics with relativistic quantum field theory, which he knew worked very well—“for all practical purposes” as he said—just as he had done with Bertlmann at CERN. But Bell’s pressing concern about the foundations of his field was never far from his mind. “I am a quantum engineer,” he once announced at the start of a talk, “but on Sundays I have principles.” Bell, normally soft-spoken, could turn on a dime if a visiting speaker said something silly about quantum foundations. “In conferences…